

By **ROHAN MURTY**



THE NEXT LABOUR REVOLUTION

THE FUTURE OF WORK RESTS ON USING TECHNOLOGY TO UNDERSTAND AND IMPROVE EMPLOYEES' EXPERIENCE AT WORK

Driven by metrics like daily active users, companies strive to engage all of us in online commerce, media, entertainment and social connections, among others. But these are all activities that we do in *addition* to work. We arguably spend more time at work than on most other activities every day. Work is an important part of our intellectual and emotional lives. It gives us financial security and a sense of purpose, meaning and identity. Hence, what we do at work and how we do it matters.

Today, office work has become digital work and the pandemic has accelerated this shift. Communication and productivity tools have helped streamline digital work to make it more efficient and less cumbersome. However, what is not well-understood is *how* we work—do we all work the same way, where do we differ, what we enjoy, what we find boring, frustrating or painful, among others. Understanding how we work is a precursor to what we can do to change our experience at work.

But, when compared to the billions invested in building social media platforms to help us connect with people, to find jobs, share cat photos, etc., there has been a much lower investment in technology to understand the human experience at work and to make it better. Case in point—when was the last time you heard of tech innovations to help teams discover opportunities for mentorship at work, mitigate frustrations, find help, or share pain?

How big is this problem? There are an estimated 500 million plus office workers world-wide who spend at least 5 hours each day on digital work. Even though the world spends trillions of dollars on office work, we have not yet seen the improvement of employee experience become an imperative economic issue that technology can address. Finally, the pandemic has isolated a large fraction of office workers at home, given them more opportunities to shift jobs across the globe, and therefore made it harder to retain talent. Hence, it is more important than ever to care about the employee experience.

Organisations do pay heed to these concerns but are stifled by lack of sufficient innovation in technology. For example, companies hire people who manually interview a few people across teams, gather high-level data through interviews and then offer advice on how to streamline work. But these approaches are incomplete, analog and not scalable. Can technology offer a